

Top 10 games this week · for Notre Dame fans

Week 1 · 2026 season · data Sep 3 · SP+ 2026
75% to make the 12-team field · proj. 10.3–1.7

YOUR GAME · SUN, SEP 6 · 1930 ET · NBC

Wisconsin (8%) at #4 Notre Dame (92%) Notre Dame -20.5

Win and Notre Dame's playoff odds are 76.6%; lose and they're 63.1%. A 13.5-point swing, the biggest thing on this page by far.

Ranked by leverage · how much the result moves Notre Dame's playoff odds, discounted by how unlikely the swing is · the boxed team is the one to pull for

1	Mon, Sep 7 · 1930 ET · ESPN	Leverage 58	Impact 52
	#19 SMU (52%) at Florida State (48%) SMU -3 · O/U 53.5		
	A SMU win happens 52% of the time and is worth 0.32 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.7% vs 74.4%) Mostly because SMU is on Notre Dame's schedule (wk 12); the better their record, the more your result against them counts (proj. 8 wins); also Florida State is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 5% of seasons).		
2	Sat, Sep 5 · 1930 ET · ABC	Leverage 24	Impact 26
	Clemson (28%) at #11 LSU (72%) LSU -10 · O/U 50.5		
	A Clemson win happens 28% of the time and is worth 0.16 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.7% vs 74.6%) Because LSU is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 16% of seasons).		
3	Sat, Sep 5 · 1530 ET · ABC	Leverage 18	Impact 19
	Baylor (32%) at Auburn (68%) Auburn -7.5 · O/U 59.5		
	A Baylor win happens 32% of the time and is worth 0.12 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.7% vs 74.5%) Because Auburn is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 6% of seasons).		
4	Fri, Sep 4 · 2100 ET · FOX	Leverage 18	Impact 45
	Fresno State (10%) at #14 USC (90%) USC -22.5 · O/U 51.5		
	A Fresno St win happens 10% of the time and is worth 0.28 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.8% vs 74.6%) Because USC is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 14% of seasons).		
5	Sun, Sep 6 · 1600 ET · NBC	Leverage 17	Impact 46
	Washington State (9%) at #17 Washington (91%) Washington -23.5 · O/U 51.5		
	A Wash St win happens 9% of the time and is worth 0.29 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.8% vs 74.6%) Because Washington is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 12% of seasons).		
6	Sat, Sep 5 · 1530 ET · CBS	Leverage 14	Impact 62
	Boise State (6%) at #2 Oregon (94%) Oregon -24.5 · O/U 51.5		
	A Boise St win happens 6% of the time and is worth 0.38 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.9% vs 74.5%) Because Oregon is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 29% of seasons).		
7	Sat, Sep 5 · 1200 ET · ABC	Leverage 12	Impact 34
	East Carolina (9%) at #13 Alabama (91%) Alabama -28.5 · O/U 52.5		
	A ECU win happens 9% of the time and is worth 0.21 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.8% vs 74.6%) Because Alabama is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 12% of seasons).		
8	Fri, Sep 4 · 2100 ET · ESPN	Leverage 12	Impact 34
	#7 Miami (91%) at Stanford (9%) Miami -24.5 · O/U 48.5		
	A Miami win happens 91% of the time and is worth 0.21 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.6% vs 74.4%) Mostly because Miami is on Notre Dame's schedule (wk 10); the better their record, the more your result against them counts (proj. 10 wins); also this affects who wins the ACC, and a champion takes an auto-bid instead of an at-large spot.		
9	Sat, Sep 5 · 1530 ET · ESPN	Leverage 12	Impact 55
	Texas State (5%) at #5 Texas (95%) Texas -29.5 · O/U 59.5		
	A Texas St win happens 5% of the time and is worth 0.34 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.9% vs 74.5%) Because Texas is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 16% of seasons).		
10	Sat, Sep 5 · 1930 ET · NBC	Leverage 11	Impact 43
	Western Michigan (6%) at #16 Michigan (94%) Michigan -27.5 · O/U 49.5		
	A W Michigan win happens 6% of the time and is worth 0.26 pts of playoff odds (Notre Dame 74.8% vs 74.5%) Because Michigan is competing with Notre Dame for an at-large spot; a loss makes them likelier to finish behind you (they block you in 12% of seasons).		

Leverage and impact are scaled 0–100 against the biggest remaining game that doesn't involve Notre Dame. Win chances from SP+ with home advantage; every number from 30,000 simulated seasons with each game flipped one at a time.